

Center-left strains over Metsola III support

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POLITICO's must-read briefing on what's driving the day in Brussels, by Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur and Gabriel Gavin. By GERARDO FORTUNA CIAO T

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CIAO THERE. Gerardo Fortuna with you this Thursday with the two World Cup finalists locked in ... although Argentina's win over England has spoiled the "all-European final" the European Commission had been hoping for ...

In today's Playbook:

- Message from Down Under: Blame Big Tech, not social media laws.
- Why renewed Middle East conflict could upend the EU's energy plans.
- Faces in the crowd: Benedetta Scuderi, Manfred Weber, Péter Szijjártó, Barry Andrews, Iratxe García, Delphine Ernotte, Kaja Kallas, Peter Liese, Adam Jarubas, Julie Inman Grant, Ursula von der Leyen, Cathy Berx, Thomas Byrne, Pietro Guastamacchia and many more

On today's Brussels Playbook Podcast: Zoya and Ian unpack the EU's mid-term reshuffle, and Roberta Metsola's chances of getting another term as Parliament chief.

DRIVING THE DAY

THE GREAT BETRAYAL? The battle over the next presidency is exposing new cracks in an informal political alliance that had been forged in response to the perceived rightward shift of the European People's Party in the EU Parliament.

Three political groupings — the Socialists and Democrats, Renew Europe and the Greens/EFA — have until now presented a united front. But that unity is fraying ahead of the chamber's midterm reshuffle, Max Grier writes in to report.

Background: Parliament President Roberta Metsola, from the EPP, is expected to seek a third term, despite the S&D's claim to the job. Group leaders insist negotiations won't begin until September, but the horse-trading is already underway — with five midterm battles brewing .

At issue: The S&D hasn't given up on securing the presidency. But as Green and Renew lawmakers see Metsola's reelection as a fait accompli, some want to start negotiating with the EPP over the divvying up of key roles.

Greens gaming it out: The Greens held an initial strategy discussion in Strasbourg last week, according to two people familiar with the talks. One camp argued the group should seek an early agreement with the EPP and Metsola to bank concessions, while others insisted it was too soon to commit.

"They have zero chances," one Green MEP said of the Socialists' ambition to dethrone Metsola. "If she's getting elected anyway, why not cut a deal with her and get something in return?," a second Green MEP asked.

Renew's price: "Informally Renew is saying we could support Metsola if we are treated well and there's a rollover of positions," a senior Renew MEP told Max, stressing the group has "no blind loyalty." Metsola, the lawmaker added, is "approachable, respectable and hardworking."

Enough to go around: Beyond the presidency there are 14 vice-presidencies, 26 committee chairmanships and 78 vice-chairmanships up for grabs. With all groupings trying to protect — or upgrade — their portfolio of positions, simply rolling over the current power-sharing deal is looking increasingly tempting.

Judgment-free friendliness: Renew and the Greens are concerned about Metsola's determination to stay on good terms with everyone, including the far right. She recently argued it was not for her to decide whom the EPP cooperates with, and allies want clearer guarantees about the EPP's dealings with the Patriots for Europe.

"We need to know where President Metsola stands," Irish liberal MEP Barry Andrews told Playbook. "Will [the far right] get top political roles if she is reelected? Will they increasingly shape decisions?"

Where this ends: The likeliest landing zone, according to two senior MEPs and two staffers granted anonymity to speak freely, is a grand bargain between the EPP, S&D and Renew: extra jobs for the Socialists in exchange for backing Metsola, plus a package of policy commitments to keep everyone on board.

Policy directions: "Our group is willing to negotiate everything," S&D leader Iratxe García told Playbook. "Negotiation will not only be about posts — it also has to be about political commitments," she said, arguing that citizens would take a dim view of lawmakers agreeing on key roles but not on the policies that define the European project.

Worst fear: Even with a deal, S&D, Renew and the Greens fear the Patriots could snatch a vice-presidency. EPP leader Manfred Weber insists that's a red line he won't cross. But the vote is secret and comes after the presidential ballot ... and recent history suggests red lines can fade.

Just this week ... On Tuesday, the EPP voted with the Patriots to block a push for further scrutiny of the far-right group's spending. A day later, Patriots votes helped the EPP protect one of its MEPs from losing parliamentary immunity in a case brought by Slovenian prosecutors.

BIG AND BREAKING

WHAT THE ... ETS? Three letters — one Brussels obsession. The Commission's long-awaited review of the carbon market lands Friday and everyone from industry to climate campaigners is sharpening their

knives.

Jumping the gun: Parliament isn't waiting for the results of the review, with the EPP securing the lead role on the ETS overhaul, according to an email seen by POLITICO. German lawmaker Peter Liese will steer the main file, while Poland's Adam Jarubas takes charge of the linked fallback benchmarks.

SANCTIONS? NEXT WEEK: EU countries have pushed the latest Russia sanctions showdown to July 22, kicking the can down the road on both the package and whether to freeze the bloc's price cap on Russian crude.

DOUBLE TROUBLE: The EU's new digital border system, the Entry/Exit System, hasn't just been causing long lines for holidaymakers at airports. It's also apparently confused by identical twins, who are getting questioned by the police as a result of a bug, as Jon Stone reports .

MADE IN CHINA: Hungary's former Foreign Minister Péter Szijjártó is joining Chinese EV giant BYD in a senior executive role, after years spent courting Chinese investment while in government. And read former White House trade adviser Peter Navarro's op-ed on why Europe should be freaked out by BYD's "pirate" business model.

SOCIAL MEDIA BAN

DOES BANNING KIDS WORK? Much of the debate about curbing social media for children in Europe is focusing on whether Australia, a pioneer of such restrictions, has shown that it can be done successfully. For those arguing against a ban, seizing on what they perceive as an Australian failure has become a strong argument.

Too soon: But in an interview with POLITICO, Australia's eSafety commissioner has hit back. Julie Inman Grant told Zoya Sheftalovich and Eliza Gkritsi that critics were "calling it too early."

Aussie feedback: The online-safety enforcer's remarks came after experts presented a report to Commission President Ursula von der Leyen on Monday, which found that Canberra's blanket ban hadn't worked. "We see a lot of circumvention and other problems in Australia," one of the experts said at a briefing. But von der Leyen hinted that the EU would nonetheless soon impose a minimum age for young internet users to access social media without parental supervision.

Inman Grant's response to the criticism: The government is trying to reverse two decades of product design aimed at keeping young people hooked, and that takes time: "No significant cultural change happened in three or six or nine months," she said. Platforms deactivated around 5 million underage accounts after the rules took effect, while surveys showed a 37 percent reduction in young people holding social media accounts, the online-safety commissioner said, while conceding implementation has been patchy.

Not can't — won't: Her office is investigating YouTube, Snap, TikTok, Instagram and Facebook for possibly breaching the laws. "I don't think it's that they cannot do it. It's that they don't want to," she said.

Precedent preoccupation: Inman Grant accused the platforms of running "smear campaigns" against her and the responsible minister, with one commissioning a report branding the Aussie policy "100 days of failure." "They don't want to set a global precedent," she said. "They were never going to be incentivized to flawlessly execute."

Tightening the screws: Australia now plans to double maximum fines and give regulators stronger powers to obtain documents and evidence from age-verification providers, helping them build court cases against non-compliant platforms.

What the platforms say: Snap and YouTube declined to comment. Meta and TikTok didn't respond before POLITICO's deadline.

Trump pressure: Inman Grant noted the hostility facing digital regulators, with the Trump administration casting overseas tech rules as attacks on American companies and free speech. "It's a challenging geopolitical environment," she said. But she argued there was safety in numbers. With some technology companies now wielding "wealth, stealth and power" greater than many governments, she said, "collective action is so important."

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

The EU has unveiled a livestock strategy . But how does it work? It's basically recasting the EU's view of cows, pigs and chickens. After years of debate about the climate effects of livestock in Europe, including whether mass culls of cows were needed to cut emissions, the strategy views livestock as an asset that supports 7 million jobs and generates €400 billion a year. The strategy takes the view that the sector's decline can be reversed and its carbon footprint cut through incentives for farmers and technological fixes.

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: On the Brussels Playbook Podcast, Ian asked you to send in your crow encounter stories (you'll have to listen to figure out why). WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shoutout.

IRAN CONFLICT RESPONSE

WAR'S BACK, BRUSSELS WAITS: Renewed strikes on Iran — including those launched overnight — are threatening to upend the EU's carefully laid plans to cope with the conflict's disruption. But despite fears of a "forever war" in the Strait of Hormuz, Brussels isn't scrambling for a new response — at least, not yet.

Friday test: The Commission is still expected to sign off Friday on a new energy package, alongside the review of the bloc's flagship carbon emissions rules, mentioned above. Capitals had already used rising energy costs to advocate for softer climate obligations. Both proposals, drafted in response to the first Iran crisis, now land as the conflict enters a more dangerous phase.

No hints: Commission spokesperson Olof Gill told Playbook the measures already in place "have provided stability in the here and now" while keeping the bloc prepared for any deterioration in the geopolitical situation. As for whether Brussels has more up its sleeve, Gill said: "We are equipped to handle all scenarios."

From the sidelines: Seven EU diplomats told Playbook there are no serious discussions about changing Europe's approach. "The truth is we're mostly spectators and have very little influence on how the situation evolves," one diplomat said. Another put it more bluntly: There is no Plan B — "at least not until energy prices really take off."

Fiscal knock-on effect: A third diplomat argued that a sustained jump in energy prices would pile pressure on governments to shield households and businesses, potentially reviving demands for greater fiscal flexibility.

“Everyone knows what’s the only real cure to the problem: seriously decrease dependencies on energy from third countries through investments in energy infrastructure,” the diplomat said. And many governments simply don’t have the money, and this could reopen the debate over giving governments more fiscal room to spend.

At sea: While Brussels waits, top diplomat Kaja Kallas heads to Djibouti today to visit the EU’s Aspides and Atalanta naval missions. “With the Strait of Hormuz effectively closed, the pressure on this route is increasing again,” an EU official told Playbook, noting that the Iran-backed Houthis remain a persistent threat to commercial shipping despite months of EU naval patrols.

Meanwhile ... U.S. President Donald Trump said in a social media post overnight that Iran had allowed a “wrongfully detained” American citizen to leave the country. “The United States of America appreciates this gesture of Goodwill by Iran!,” Trump said. CNN later identified the person as Dena Karari, who had been held in Iran since 2025.

EU BUDGET CORNER

GERMANY PUSHES BACK ON OWN RESOURCES: New EU-wide taxes won’t crack the code in the bloc’s ongoing budget negotiations, the German government wrote in an internal note seen by my Berlin-based colleague Jasper Bennink. The only workable solution involves big cuts to the EU cash pot.

Franco-German summit: The note sets up tensions ahead of a meeting today in North Rhine-Westphalia between French President Emmanuel Macron and German Chancellor Friedrich Merz, writes Gregorio Sorigi. Paris intends to discuss proposed new levies, known as own resources, which it supports and are the condition for Paris to agree to a budget deal, an Élysée official said.

Keep it real: But Germany argues in the document that the potential revenue from the levies “is nowhere near enough to offset the proposed sharp increase in the budget volume.” The leaked note, drafted in preparation for a meeting of EU ambassadors on July 8, suggested that “we should ... not delude ourselves.”

In a further swipe: Berlin suggested that the Commission’s five proposed levies — minus a business tax that’s opposed by most governments — will generate €24 billion per year instead of the €65 billion initially forecast by the Commission.

German tiger: This dovetails Germany’s aggressive stance in the budget negotiations. In a separate internal document, Berlin backed an eye-watering €400 billion budget cut, roughly a fifth of the Commission’s overall proposal.

Seeing all the cards: To facilitate a budget deal under its rotating Council presidency, Ireland’s ambassador to the EU will attend the informal meetings of rival camps of net payers and recipients, said Ireland’s Europe Minister Thomas Byrne.

9 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

EU TECH SOVEREIGNTY PARADOX: Europe wants to own more of its technological future, but the system through which it builds defense capability continues to make it dependent on technologies it does not fully control. A Pro Analysis report, set for publication at 7 a.m., plumbs the depths of the continent's technological dependence on the U.S.

EU-U.S. TROUBLE AT THE U.N.: EU countries on Wednesday discussed a U.S.-led U.N. declaration on free speech that takes aim at "new laws and regulatory frameworks." That's diplomatic shorthand for the EU's Digital Services Act, according to two officials and a draft seen by POLITICO's Eliza Gkritsi. (More in Morning Tech , for subscribers).

THANKS, GOOGLE: Brussels' coffers just got an unexpected windfall. The Commission confirmed to POLITICO's Gregorio Sorgi — here, for Pro readers — that Google's €4.6 billion antitrust fine will flow into the EU coffers this year — roughly 2 percent of the bloc's annual budget.

'WE SCREWED UP': U.S. Vice President JD Vance has said the Trump administration "absolutely screwed up" the rollout of the Epstein files, conceding that the White House botched its communications .

OFF AIR? France's public broadcaster could disappear altogether if Marine Le Pen's National Rally follows through on its privatization plans, France Télévisions chief Delphine Ernotte warned in an interview with POLITICO .

PROTECTION EXTENDED ... WITH A CAVEAT: EU countries have agreed to prolong temporary protection for Ukrainian refugees until 2028. One notable exception: Men who could be called up to fight.

JUST ANOTHER DAY IN KYIV: Von der Leyen's visit to Ukraine was interrupted by air raid sirens, forcing journalists and officials into a shelter. "This is what Ukrainian people experience daily because of Putin's war," Commission spokesperson Paula Pinho posted on X afterward.

POST-GRAHAM ERA: Ukraine thinks it can keep Trump onside — even without the man who was one of the country's loudest Republican champions .

FUNDING CULTURE WARS: The U.S. State Department is releasing nearly \$5 million to promote what it calls "Western civilizational heritage" in Europe. German Chancellor Friedrich Merz is already pushing back .

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Sunny, top of 29C.

MEP ALTERCATION: Brussels police appear to forcibly remove Green MEP Benedetta Scuderi from a Brussels street in a video the Italian lawmaker posted on Instagram. The incident occurred near a right-wing anti-immigration demonstration. Asked by Playbook whether she would raise the incident in Parliament, Scuderi said she hadn't decided yet and would consider her next steps in coming days.

NO BANGS, PLEASE: Tomorrowland Belgium may still get the music, but not its iconic fireworks. Belgian authorities have banned pyrotechnics at this weekend's festival, after local mayors and Antwerp Governor Cathy Berx followed the advice of the fire brigade, amid dry conditions and an elevated wildfire risk.

SPOTTED ... at Wednesday's remembrance ceremony for victims of climate change in the Vallée du Maelbeek Garden, just off Rue de la Loi: Belgian Climate Minister Jean-Luc Crucke; Ans Persoons, environment state secretary for the Brussels-Capital Region; Kurt Vandenberghe, director-general of the European Commission's climate department; Belgian Green MEP Sara Matthieu; Bas Smets, a landscape architect who will design a monument for climate victims; and dozens of activists, alongside survivors of climate disasters in Europe.

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: Tomorrow's Franco-German Ministerial Council is expected to deliver results . Yet the meeting is facing greater uncertainty than ever.

London: Lionel Messi may have robbed Keir Starmer of a trip to the World Cup final, but the outgoing prime minister's international commitments continue .

Paris: Former President François Hollande outlined an ambitious list of ways he wants to "protect" the French People. But will he run?

Washington PM: Fealty towards Trump by candidates for key positions in the U.S. administration may impress the president . But how does it play with GOP lawmakers?

AGENDA

— EU Foreign Policy Chief Kaja Kallas visits EU naval operations Aspides and Atalanta in Djibouti and signs the EU-Djibouti Status of Forces Agreement for Operation ASPIDES with Foreign Minister Abdoukader Houssein Omar and Defence Minister Hassan Omar Mohamed Bourhan.

— Coreper II meets at 12:30 p.m.

— European Commission Executive Vice-President Henna Virkkunen receives Director Reporters Without Borders Director General Thibaut Bruttin.

— Trade Commissioner Maroš Šefčovič and Economy Commissioner Valdis Dombrovskis receive Turkish Trade Minister Ömer Bolat.

— Šefčovič receives Minister of Foreign Affairs, Regional Integration and International Trade of Mauritius Dhananjay Ramful.

— German Chancellor Friedrich Merz meets French president Emmanuel Macron.

BIRTHDAYS

Former MEPs Nedzhmi Ali, Julia Reid and Marcus Pretzell; Adobe's Fleur Veldhuijzen van Zanten; Opleo Avocats' Guillaume Blandet; SCOR Chairman Fabrice Brégier; German politician Sahra Wagenknecht; journalists Charles Gittins and Aubry Touriel; Flix's Soline Whooley; Gordon Sondland, former U.S. ambassador to the EU; European Commission's Philip Tod; Spanish National Radio correspondent David Vidueiro Jiménez; Euractiv's Pietro Guastamacchia.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Grier, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Ferdinand Knapp and Milena Wälde, editor James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

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